SimpleSwing

SimpleSwing will be a simple to use recording device, allowing golfers to review their swing in a short simple video clip.

The proposal

SimpleSwing is a local-first, hands-free mobile golf swing recording application designed to eliminate range recording friction and end SaaS subscription fatigue. Traditional golf video tools force players into $60–$120/year subscriptions bundled with complex AI diagnostic bloat. SimpleSwing provides an intuitive, high-utility alternative: set up your phone on a tripod, hit your shot, and let your smartwatch or acoustic impact detection automatically buffer, trim, and present instant slow-motion video replays. Offered at a transparent £14.99 one-time purchase, SimpleSwing leverages on-device hardware to eliminate cloud backend hosting costs, delivering exceptional unit economics and pure utility for the everyday golfer.

Unit economics

Unlike traditional SaaS competitors that rely on cloud storage vaults and costly remote server AI processing, SimpleSwing operates under a 100% local-first architecture. All frame buffering, automated video trimming, and pose tracking run directly on the user's iPhone Neural Engine and RAM, with finalized 120fps video files stored locally in the native iOS Photos library. Consequently, ongoing server hosting and video bandwidth costs are £0/month. This zero-overhead model allows SimpleSwing to offer a competitive one-time purchase (£14.99) while maintaining near-100% net profit margins after Apple’s 15% Small Business Program commission, insulating the business against burn rate risks as user volume scales.

Why the Demand Exists

1. The "Trimming Friction" Problem: Golfers hate manually pressing record, stepping up to address, hitting, walking back, hitting stop, and dragging sliders to isolate the 2-second swing out of a 45-second clip.

2. Current Pricing Fatigue: Popular market leaders carry subscriptions ranging from $60/year to $120+/year. Many average high-to-mid handicappers feel overbilled for features they never use, such as full AI skeletal diagnostic models, remote pro-coaching subscriptions, or cloud video vaults.

3. Desire for Simplicity: Most range-goers want one basic outcome: Set phone on tripod \rightarrow hit ball \rightarrow look at screen \rightarrow see immediate, hands-free slow-mo replay of the swing.

The Competitive Landscape

If you launch a cheap or low-cost app, you face tough competition from existing options:

- Freemium Dominators (Swing Profile, V1 Golf, MotionEdge): Offer free tiers that include basic video capture, drawing tools, and standard replays. They monetise via premium tiers for unlimited auto-trimming, cloud storage, or AI coaching.

- Free Hardware App-Ecosystems: Hardware companies (like Garmin with the R10 or Rapsodo) provide free video auto-trimming inside their native apps once a golfer owns the launch monitor.

To succeed with a cheap app (e.g., $1.99–$2.99/month or a one-time $10–$15 purchase), you must solve the technical bar while ditching the bloated features:

1. "Local-First" Auto-Trimming

Instead of processing video in the cloud (which incurs server hosting costs that force high subscription fees), leverage on-device machine learning (Apple CoreML / Android ML Kit). A simple, lightweight algorithm that listens for the impact sound (audio trigger) or detects motion stopping/starting can auto-trim swings locally on the phone at zero server cost to you.

2. Hands-Free Apple Watch / WearOS Triggering

A major complaint with budget apps is range control. A simple app with a one-tap Apple Watch trigger (or voice command like "Record Shot") that captures the last 5 seconds from a buffer instantly solves a huge user pain point without requiring complex video AI.

3. No Subscription / Low One-Off Pricing

Golfers are exhausted by $10/month SaaS apps. Positioning an app as a one-time pay-to-own tool ($9.99) or an ultra-cheap annual pass ($12/year) that

handles only smart recording, instant auto-replay, and simple drawing tools creates a compelling value proposition over the $100+/year alternatives.

Build outline

Building an app with these specific constraints is technically straightforward, but mechanically nuanced.

For an experienced iOS/Swift developer, creating a basic, working prototype (MVP) takes 2 to 4 weeks. However, making it seamless under range conditions requires solving specific platform edge cases.

1. "Local-First" Auto-Trimming (Difficulty: Medium)

Because you want zero cloud processing, the trimming algorithm must run on-device using iOS AVFoundation and Apple framework models. You have two options for implementation:

A. Audio Peak / Sound Classification Trigger (Easiest)

How it works: Keep a rolling 5-second video buffer in memory using AVCaptureMovieFileOutput. When the microphone picks up a sharp acoustic transient (the distinct sound of club-on-ball impact), trigger the save function.

Implementation: Apple’s SoundAnalysis framework + CreateML allows you to train a lightweight model directly on 20–30 audio clips of a golf driver/iron impact.

The Catch: At a busy driving range, adjacent golfers hitting balls nearby will create false triggers. You must write amplitude/frequency thresholding or directional mic limits to ignore adjacent mats.

B. On-Device Motion / Pose Trimming (Slightly Harder, Most Accurate)

How it works: Use Apple’s native Vision framework (VNDetectHumanBodyPoseRequest) running at 60fps/120fps on the phone's Neural Engine.

Implementation: Track key joints (wrists, shoulders). Detect when the hands rise (backswing), drop rapidly (downswing), and decelerate (finish).

The Advantage: Zero server costs, hyper-accurate trimming, and immunity to noisy range environments.

2. Apple Watch / WearOS Triggering (Difficulty: Easy to Medium)

SimpleSwing accommodates all golfers through a dual-trigger architecture. For standard users, on-device acoustic impact detection automatically captures and trims swings from a rolling video buffer with zero accessories needed. For smartwatch owners, an optional Apple Watch and WearOS companion app allows seamless wrist-tap triggers, catering to both casual players and gear-focused golfers alike.

A. Remote Button / Gesture Trigger (Very Easy)

How it works: Create a basic watchOS companion app using WatchConnectivity (WCSession). Tapping "Record" or double-tapping the watch screen sends an instant message over Bluetooth to tell the phone: "Save the last 6 seconds of buffer video to local storage."

Dev Effort: Under 200 lines of Swift/SwiftUI code.

B. High-Frequency Motion Sensor Auto-Detect (Medium)

How it works: Use CoreMotion on watchOS to stream high-frequency accelerometer/gyroscope data (100\text{Hz}) from the wrist. Detect the sudden rotational acceleration spike of the swing downswing to signal the phone camera.

The Catch: watchOS restricts background sensor streaming to preserve battery. You must wrap the range session inside an active HKWorkoutSession (e.g., a "Golf Workout") so Apple allows uninterrupted high-frequency sensor access.

3. No Subscription / Low One-Off Pricing (Difficulty: Business Unit Economics)

From a pure engineering perspective, this feature makes the app radically easier to build and maintain than its SaaS competitors:

Zero Backend Costs: By handling frame buffering, trimming, and video storage locally on the phone's hardware, your server hosting costs are $0/month.

No Authentication Overhead: You don't need user login systems, Firebase accounts, Stripe subscription webhooks, or database infrastructure.

Low Support Overhead: Storing videos locally in the user's native Photos library (Photos framework) saves you from building cloud video vaults or paying for AWS S3 bucket storage.

Potential charging structure

To monetise a lightweight, local-first golf swing app, your pricing must exploit the "SaaS fatigue" felt by everyday golfers.

Because on-device AI and local circular video buffering eliminate recurring server/cloud storage costs, you do not need a high monthly subscription to be profitable. Positioning the app as an affordable utility—rather than an expensive digital coach—will capture market share from tools charging £60 to £100+ per year.

1. Recommended Pricing Tiers

A. Freemium Model with a One-Time Unlock (Primary Recommendation)

Free Tier ("The Range Hook"):

Manual recording & basic trimming.

3 automatic Watch/Sound triggers per range session.

Standard video playback with basic line drawing tools.

Pro Paid Tier (One-Time Purchase: £14.99 / $19.99):

Lifetime License.

Unlimited hands-free Apple Watch / WearOS triggers.

Unlimited local-first auto-trimming (sound/motion detection).

Frame-by-frame scrubbing, grid overlays, and slow-mo exports directly to Apple Photos.

B. Alternative: Ultra-Low Annual Pass

If you want recurring revenue for maintenance updates, use a low-friction subscription:

£9.99 / year or £1.99 / month with a 7-day free trial.

Why this works: It sits below the mental threshold of impulse cancellation (unlike V1's £70/yr or GolfFix's £100/yr).

2. Strategic Positioning & Value Proposition

"No AI lesson advice you didn't ask for. No $100/year subscriptions. Just open the app, swing your club, and watch your slow-mo replay on your watch or phone."

3. Monetisation Expansion (In-App Upsells)

Keep the core recording functionality behind the single unlock fee, but offer optional, modular one-time add-ons for advanced users:

1. Multi-Camera Sync Module (£4.99 one-time): Connect an iPad (down-the-line) and iPhone (face-on) simultaneously via local Wi-Fi/Bluetooth to save dual-angle clips automatically.

2. Pro Export Package (£2.99 one-time): Export side-by-side comparison videos, custom drawing overlays, or high-fps GIFs for social media sharing.

4. Conversion Tactics for Launch

The "3 Free Triggers per Session" Hook: Give non-paying users a taste of automatic Watch/sound triggers. Once they experience hitting a ball and looking up to see their swing auto-trimmed, hitting the paywall after 3 shots yields high conversion.

Launch Discounting: Offer an initial £9.99 "Early Bird" lifetime price for the first 1,000 downloads to generate App Store reviews, range word-of-mouth.

Other apps in the market

The competitive landscape for golf swing video apps can be divided into four distinct categories, ranging from high-subscription AI analyzers to simple standalone recording tools.

1. Hands-Free & Auto-Trimming Range Competitors (Direct Competitors)

Swing Profile

The Positioning: Long-standing market leader for hands-free range recording.

How it works: Set your phone on a tripod; motion-detection algorithms automatically detect address, impact, and follow-through, trimming the clip down to 2–3 seconds and auto-drawing basic plane lines.

Pricing Model: Free tier allows only 3 saved swings; Premium (Elite) subscription costs ~$49.99 to $99.99/year.

Weakness: Dated user interface and high subscription costs for simple auto-trimming.

DeepSwing

The Positioning: Modern mobile app combining automatic video capture with local-first processing.

How it works: Uses phone-based computer vision to auto-detect swings, measure estimated clubhead/ball speed, and provide immediate audio/spoken feedback without cloud processing.

Pricing Model: ~€59.99/year (~$65/year).

2. High-End AI Diagnostic & Coaching Apps

GolfFix

The Positioning: Automated "AI Golf Coach" targeting solo practice.

How it works: Auto-captures your swing and uses skeletal body tracking to run 40+ diagnostic checks (e.g., sway, head loss, over-the-top path), assigning a numerical swing score and recommending specific drills.

Pricing Model: ~$99.99/year (or ~$14.99/month).

Weakness: Suffers from "AI noise"—many golfers complain about false diagnostic ratings and aggressive subscription paywalls.

V1 Golf (V1 Sports)

The Positioning: The industry incumbent for human coach collaboration and classic video analysis.

How it works: Manual recording, frame-by-frame scrubbing, high-resolution drawing tools, side-by-side PGA Tour model swing comparisons, and direct integration with certified instructors.

Pricing Model: $69.99 to $120+/year (V1 GOLF+ / V1sion).

Weakness: Heavy emphasis on manual stop/start recording and cloud subscriptions rather than hands-free automated practice.

Onform

The Positioning: Multi-camera video capture built for teaching pros, academies, and serious athletes.

How it works: Auto-detects shots (iOS), syncs multiple device angles (e.g., iPhone and iPad), and integrates launch monitor data.

Pricing Model: $99.99/year for individual athletes; $240 to $700+/year for coaches.

3. All-in-One GPS & Scorecard Apps with Swing Add-Ons

18Birdies & Golfshot

The Positioning: Popular course GPS and scorecard apps expanding into swing analysis.

How it works: Use Apple Watch sensors (CoreMotion) for automatic shot/swing detection on the course, paired with AI swing rating modules.

Pricing Model: Included as part of broader premium passes ($99.99/year).

Weakness: Built primarily for course management and on-round scoring, making them bloated for quick range practice sessions.

4. Niche & Pay-Once Competitors (The Gap Opportunity)

SwingDraw / Golf Swing Recorder

The Positioning: Simple, utility-focused iOS tools that emphasize manual drawing, local storage, or one-off purchases.

Pricing Model: Typically pay-once ($5 – $15) or low-cost subscriptions.

Weakness: Many of these smaller utilities lack seamless Apple Watch gesture triggers or rely purely on manual button presses rather than smart audio/motion auto-trimming.